

The four types of consistency in design

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We hear a lot about design systems, pattern libraries, and how large design teams are leveraging design systems to build products. Why is there a sudden shift in companies to create design systems, the most straightforward answer is consistency?

Consistent systems are more usable and learnable when similar components (e.g., buttons or drop-downs) or interactions are expressed in similar ways. A consistent product transfers knowledge intuitively to new contexts, allows users to learn new things rapidly, and focusses attention on relevant aspects of a task.

There are four types of consistency: **Aesthetic, Functional, Internal, and External.**

Aesthetic consistency *applies to a consistent style and appearance* (e.g., a logo that uses a consistent font, color, and graphic). Aesthetic consistency enhances recognition, communicates membership, and sets emotional expectations.



Coca-cola is universally recognized

For example, Coca-cola is immediately recognizable by people around the world because the logo is simple, it uses a single print color, and the font has never changed. The logo has become associated with the young crowd and informs people how they should feel about the brand-i.e., admired.

Functional consistency *applies to consistent meaning and action* (e.g., turning a switch, lights a bulb).



A switch turns on a bulb.

Functional consistency improves usability and learn-ability by allowing people to leverage existing knowledge about how the design functions.



Walkman has symbols to control the playback of a cassette

For example, a Walkman has control symbols for rewind, play, forward, which are used on devices ranging from slide projectors to MP3 music players.



The symbols used in a Walkman are used on modern audio players

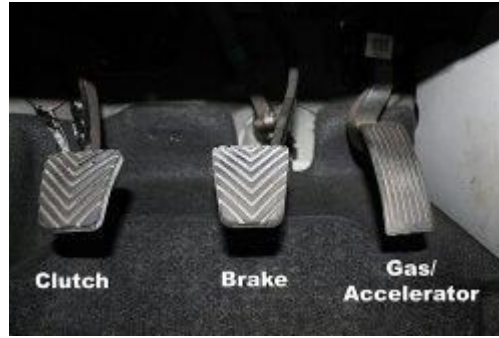
The consistent use of these symbols on new devices enables people to leverage existing knowledge about how the controls function, which makes the new devices more convenient to use and learn.

Internal consistency: applies to consistent design with other elements in the system (e.g., signs within an airport are consistent with one another).



Internal consistency fosters trust within people subconsciously; it is an excellent indicator that a system has been designed, and not mixed. Within any logical grouping, elements should be aesthetically and functionally consistent with one another.

External consistency applies to consistency with other elements in the environment (e.g., Accelerator, Brake, and Clutch are placed in the same way throughout all manufacturers worldwide).



External consistency extends the benefits of internal consistency across multiple, independent systems. It is more difficult to achieve because different systems rarely observe common design standards.

Consider aesthetic and functional consistency in all aspects of your product. Use aesthetic consistency to establish a unique identity that can be easily recognized. Use functional consistency to simplify usability and ease of learning. Ensure that your product is always internally consistent and externally consistent to the highest degree. When universal design standards exist, observe them.

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